

The Six Directions Ritual as Useless or Meaningful

Bhante Bodhidhamma · DhammaBytes · 14:01

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

So now I want to move on to more familiar stuff about how we treat each other. There's a discourse here which looks at worshipping in the six directions. I shall read it and then we'll see what we can make of it.

Thus have I heard. On one occasion the Blessed One was dwelling at Rājagaha at the Bamboo Grove in the Squirrel Sanctuary. So Rājagaha was the main dwelling place of Bimbisāra and his kingdom would have been along just north of the Ganges, that area. Then Sigālaka the householder's son, having got up early and gone out of Rājagaha, was paying homage with wet clothes and hair and with joined palms to the different directions: to the east, the south, the west, the north, the nadir and the zenith.

His father has died and it would seem that one way of paying respects was to wet your hair, wet your clothes. I've not been able to find out why that is. Presumably some sort of tears, maybe some sort of expression of sorrow, I don't know. And the Blessed One having risen early and dressed, took his robe and bowl and went to Rājagaha for alms. And seeing Sigālaka paying homage to the different directions he said, "How so? Why have you got up early to pay homage to the different directions?"

"Venerable sir, my father, when he was dying, told me to do so. And so out of respect for my father's words, which I revere, honour and hold sacred, I have got up early to pay homage in this way to the six directions."

"But householder's son, that is not the right way to pay homage to the six directions according to the noble one's discipline."

So Sigālaka is obviously one of his students.

"Well, venerable sir, how should one pay homage to the six directions according to the noble one's discipline? It would be good if the Blessed One would teach me the proper way to pay homage to the six directions according to the noble one's discipline."

"Then listen and attend carefully, householder's son, and I will speak."

That's good stuff, isn't it?

"Yes, venerable sir," Sigāḷaka said. And the Blessed One said this: "And how, householder's son, does the noble disciple protect the six directions?"

So here you see, not pay homage but protect. These six things are to be regarded as the six directions. Now before I tell you what they are, you have to guess. Each direction is to do with a relationship that we have, and he's basically saying that there are these six directions which he gives a certain relationship that we have, for instance with parents, workplace and so on.

So if you think of six people, how would you put them in order? Who would be your first? You don't have to shout it now, just in your mind. Who would be the first people you would pay homage to or pay respect to, or as he says, to protect? In other words, to send out loving-kindness. It's a protection, a protection, a blessing. It's a blessing. After the first, who would you then send out your loving-kindness to? Number two, number three, who would you send out your loving-kindness to? Number four, number five and number six.

So the six directions are east, so you start facing the east where the sun rises. East and then you go round: east, south, west, north, below the nadir, and the zenith. So you're moving round. You can imagine him doing so. He's facing the sun, the rising sun in the morning, turns to the south, turns to the west, turns to the north, all below him, all above him.

"These six things are to be regarded as the six directions. The east denotes mother and father. The south denotes teachers. The west denotes wife and children. The north denotes friends and companions. The nadir denotes servants, workers and helpers. And the zenith denotes ascetics and brahmins."

So we can, as it were, compare our value systems with those of his times, because this would have been quite general, the way that he's split society up like this. So he puts enormous stress on mother and father, and we'll come to that another time. And then his wife and children. Then his friends and companions. So presumably with wife and children it's also relatives. Then his friends and companions.

Now the nadir, he's obviously a rich person because here it talks about servants, workers and helpers. But it would mean your working companions, your livelihood. So remember that's important in the Buddhist teaching. He actually puts it as one of the Eightfold Path: Right Livelihood. So all those people involved in your livelihood.

And then finally up above, ascetics and brahmins. So the ascetics were the type of people that he would have been classed with, the *samana*. And the brahmins were the priestly caste.

Now the other thing to notice about this is the way that he changes ritual. In the ten *fetters*, one of the fetters is wrong rites and rituals. And this is what we get rid of when we enter into stream entry, like the first level of sanctity, the first noble level. And what is meant there, not that rituals themselves need be

useless, but exactly why you do them.

So bowing to the Buddha and repeating the verses, the *vipassanā* verses, is all well and good. But in terms of the process of awakening it really doesn't have much weight. It's a reminder and if we make it as part of that practice to, as it were, get us into the *vipassanā* practice then all well and good. But in itself doesn't really take us very far. So all these things like lighting candles, refuges and precepts, they all have their place but in a sense they're worthless unless we do the real practice.

So here's Sigālaka and what exactly he was doing we don't know, but basically he was paying respects to the east, south and west. He was going around paying respects, exactly what that entails he doesn't say, but he was doing something which the Buddha thought, well, that's absolutely useless. So he told him instead, using the same ritual, to actually apply loving-kindness in all these directions, and therefore he makes the ritual something worthwhile on the spiritual path.

So in our lives everything we do has to have that connection with the spiritual path. And although you wouldn't call them a ritual, they are in fact in some ways little rituals. For instance, just the whole process of the rising in the morning, from the moment you get up until you're ready to face the world, all that business of getting out of bed and washing, all that stuff, that can become a ritual, in that broad sense of the word, of making it meaningful to spiritual life.

So a ritual can be something that you're doing on a regular basis, something that you do all the time, round and round and round, like brushing your teeth. You can take it down to that level, in my understanding. And a ritual, of course, on its far end can be rather superstitious. You know, like every time you say something like, "I'm healthy," touch wood. That's a complete waste of time. But you feel good when you do it, because something in you says it's okay.

Just to reinforce that, there's a lovely little story where the Buddha sneezes. And the monks and all the lay people, especially the monks and nuns, they all offer blessings, like we would say, "God bless you," or something like that. And he says, "Does that help?" And they say, "No." He says, "Well, don't do it. Don't do it, because it's useless."

So, not before too long, the lay people start complaining, because when they sneeze, the monks aren't blessing them. So the monks came back to the Buddha and said, "Look, we've stopped doing these blessings for people with colds and sneezes." And he says, "Oh well, bless them. Because they're complaining," he says, "oh well, bless them."

So it's like if you're ready at that level of spiritual development to realise that some things are absolutely useless, then you'll stop doing it. But on the other hand, there's no harm in it. That's what he says, there's no harm in it. It's the same when somebody says to him that his students are going to these other shrines to pay respects to these gods and other people and he says it's no harm. It's just in a sense it's on the level of being useless but it's not particularly harmful.

So that's how we have this practice, that's how the practice came about of loving-kindness in the six directions. Now you can take it further than that because you can go in all sorts of directions and you can go east, east-south, southeast, and you go to all the points on the compass. And we had, I'll just finish off with this little thing, we had this rather lovely monk come from Burma to join us once at the Vihāra, and he wanted to do this practice with us, so he started off by, "All beings in the east, may they be happy and peaceful. All beings in the southeast." And he got completely confused. And we all burst out laughing. And that was the end of that practice. He completely lost his compass points. He wasn't used to it.

But in fact, that is the classic way of developing *jhāna*, in developing absorptions in loving-kindness. So you repeat things, it's like a mantra and you keep repeating and eventually the heart moves, the heart rises and you start getting these lovely feelings. And it's done through this process because it demands concentration. You've got to know where you're going. Get the direction wrong and that's it, you've had it.

So that's the beginning of these scriptures in this particular book, telling us how to behave, giving us some sort of guidance in daily life. So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be fully liberated knowing which way you're facing, sooner rather than later. Thank you very much.

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